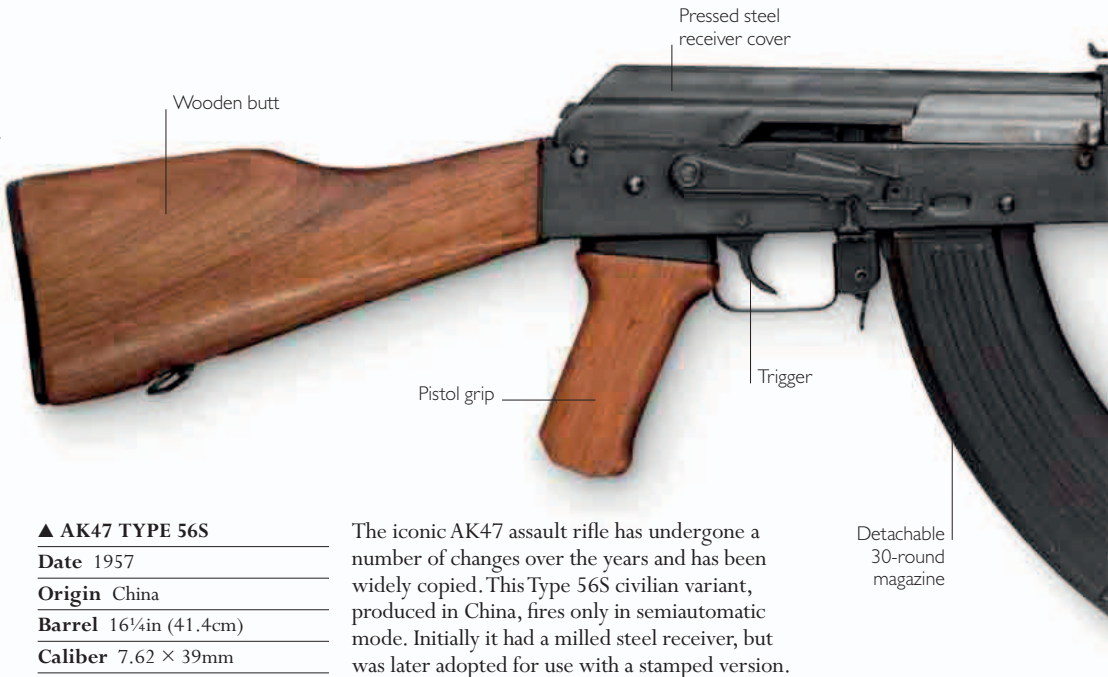


ASSAULT RIFLES

(1947–75)

If there is a quintessential firearm of the post-World War II period, it is the assault rifle (see pp.244–45). Chambered for short-case, medium- or small-caliber cartridges, the assault rifle is distinguished by its high-capacity magazine and ability to function in semi- or full-automatic modes. Though the idea was first developed at the end of World War I, the assault rifle was technically born in 1949 when the AK47 (see pp.248–49), designed by Soviet arms engineer Mikhail Kalashnikov, entered service. Now the weapon of choice on five continents, the assault rifle has become so well-known that even its blacked-out profile is immediately recognized by most people.



▲ AK47 TYPE 56S

Date	1957
Origin	China
Barrel	16¼in (41.4cm)
Caliber	7.62 × 39mm

The iconic AK47 assault rifle has undergone a number of changes over the years and has been widely copied. This Type 56S civilian variant, produced in China, fires only in semiautomatic mode. Initially it had a milled steel receiver, but was later adopted for use with a stamped version.



▲ AK74

Date	1974
Origin	Soviet Union
Barrel	16¼in (41.5cm)
Caliber	5.45 × 39mm

In 1974, the design of the Kalashnikov (AK47) was modified to improve its performance. The caliber was reduced to 5.45mm, stamped components replaced those that had been previously machined from solid steel, and a plastic magazine was substituted for the earlier metal version. This resulted in a much lighter rifle that still had the reliability of its predecessor.